

same as it had been. I bought and sold oil leases, and prospected and drilled for oil.

As the Getty Oil Company's wealth increased, so did my own in proportion to my 30-percent share in the firm—and I was also embarked on profitable ventures on my own account. All these things kept me very busy—too busy to pay more than cursory attention to how much money I was actually making. Then, one day, I stopped and took detailed stock of my financial situation. I suddenly realized that I had gone a very long way toward accomplishing what I'd set out to do in September 1914. I had built the foundations of a business of my own in the American oil industry. I was not quite 24, but I had become a successful independent oil operator. And I had made my first million dollars. I was a millionaire!

Until then, my life had been devoted chiefly to growing up, obtaining an education and establishing a business.

Now I found I'd made enough money to meet any personal requirements I might conceivably have in the foreseeable future. I made a headstrong snap decision to forget all about work thereafter and to concentrate on playing, on enjoying myself.

My decision was influenced—at least in part—by the fact that there was a war raging in Europe. Although the United States had not yet entered World War One, I felt certain that American participation in the conflict was inevitable. I'd already filed official applications to serve in either the Air Service—my first choice—or the Field Artillery when and if the U.S. declared war. I was sure it would be only a matter of time before I received my orders, and I wanted to relax and have fun before they arrived.

My mother, father and I had made our permanent home in Los Angeles, California, since 1906. I'd attended school

10

and college in California before going on to Oxford and then, later, starting my business career in the Oklahoma oil fields. I loved California and the easy, informal and extremely pleasant life that prevailed there in those days.